

DPSH MUN 2026

ECOSOC

**Steering Economic Fortunes , Empowering
Financial Resilience!**

UNITED NATIONS ECONOMIC AND SOCIAL COUNCIL



DPSH MUN 2026



AGENDA:

“Facilitating Sustainable Economic Recovery and
Reconstruction in Post-Conflict States.”

Committee Overview and Mandate

Introduction

The United Nations Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC) was established under Article 7 of the Charter of the United Nations (1945) as one of the six principal organs of the UN, tasked with coordinating the economic, social, and related work of the seventeen UN specialized agencies, ten functional commissions, and five regional commissions. ECOSOC serves as the central platform for fostering debate, reflection, and innovative thinking on sustainable development, convening the UN system, Member States, civil society, and the private sector around the achievement of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development. Comprising 54 Member States elected by the General Assembly for staggered three-year terms, ECOSOC holds a annual cycle of meetings culminating in a four-week substantive session each July, alternating between New York and Geneva.

ECOSOC's mandate, most clearly outlined under Articles 62 through 66 of the UN Charter, empowers it to make or initiate studies and reports on international economic, social, cultural, educational, health, and related matters; to make recommendations to the General Assembly, UN Member States, and specialized agencies; to prepare draft conventions for submission to the General Assembly; to call international conferences; and to coordinate the activities of the specialized agencies through consultation with and recommendations to them. Council resolutions are non-binding, but carry significant normative and political weight, often shaping the work of subsidiary bodies and funds such as the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), the World Food Programme (WFP), the United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF), and the Office of the UN High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR).

Governance, Mandate, Membership, and Structure

ECOSOC's work is organized through subsidiary bodies including the High-Level Political Forum on Sustainable Development (HLPF), which reviews progress on the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs); the Development Cooperation Forum; and the annual Forum on Financing for Development Follow-up (FfD Forum), which brings together Member States, international financial institutions, and development partners to address financing gaps for developing and fragile economies. ECOSOC also maintains close coordination with the Peacebuilding Commission and the UN Inter-Agency Standing Committee (IASC), reflecting its role at the intersection of the humanitarian, development, and peace pillars of the UN system — the so-called 'triple nexus' that is especially relevant to conflict-affected and fragile states.

Facilitating Sustainable Economic Recovery and Reconstruction in Post-Conflict States

Within this architecture, ECOSOC does not have an operational or peacekeeping mandate; its comparative advantage lies in convening financing conversations, setting normative economic and social policy, and coordinating the specialized agencies and international financial institutions (the World Bank Group and the International Monetary Fund) that carry out reconstruction and recovery work on the ground. It is this convening and coordinating function that the Council is being asked to exercise on the present agenda item.

Background

Conflict remains one of the single greatest obstacles to sustainable development in the twenty-first century. Nearly one billion people — roughly one in eight people worldwide — live in the 38 states the International Monetary Fund classifies as fragile and conflict-affected (FCS), a group that accounts for almost half of all low-income countries. Fragility and conflict rarely respect borders: they destabilize balance of payments, disrupt trade and financial flows, drive forced displacement into neighboring states, and can reverse decades of development progress within a matter of years. Since 2020 alone, 25 fragile and conflict-affected states have received approximately USD 50 billion in IMF emergency financing or commitments, underscoring both the scale of need and the international community's continued reliance on emergency, rather than structural, financing tools.

The compounding effect of overlapping crises has only intensified in the current biennium. A UN Department of Economic and Social Affairs report presented to ECOSOC noted that deepening geopolitical fragmentation and conflict are jeopardizing decades of development progress, with the escalation of conflict in the Middle East triggering a significant shock to an already fragile global economy, with developing countries absorbing the consequences through higher energy costs, disrupted trade, food price volatility, and worsening debt sustainability. Post-conflict states therefore face a uniquely difficult recovery arithmetic: reconstruction needs measured in the hundreds of billions of dollars, domestic revenue bases shattered by war, and access to concessional international capital that remains, in the words of UN and partner agencies, 'too often missed' at the moment it is most needed.

Financing Reconstruction: Bridging the Gap Between Relief and Development Finance

A central obstacle to post-conflict recovery is the financing gap between short-term humanitarian relief, which is well-funded and rapidly deployable, and long-term development finance, which is typically unavailable to fragile and conflict-affected markets that fall below investment grade.

At an ECOSOC Financing for Development Forum side event in April 2026, the UN Development Programme (UNDP), the UN Capital Development Fund (UNCDF), and the Qatar Fund for Development jointly called for new, scaled financing solutions, warning that capital remains scarce in fragile and crisis-affected settings and that opportunities for decisive early recovery are too often missed. Mechanisms such as the UNDP-UNCDF ReStart Fund attempt to close this gap through catalytic, risk-sharing instruments that stabilize financial systems, sustain lending to small businesses, and crowd in larger pools of private capital before irreversible economic collapse occurs — an approach piloted through the Financing for Recovery and Resilience programme in the State of Palestine.

The scale of recent damage assessments illustrates why innovative financing is so urgently needed. The World Bank, UN, and EU's Rapid Damage and Needs Assessment (RDNA5) for Ukraine, released in February 2026, estimated reconstruction and recovery needs at almost USD 588 billion over the next decade — nearly three times Ukraine's estimated 2025 GDP — with housing damages alone reaching approximately USD 61 billion and direct war damage exceeding USD 195 billion. In Gaza, the final Rapid Damage and Needs Assessment released in April 2026 placed recovery and reconstruction needs at USD 71.4 billion over a decade, including USD 26.3 billion required within the first eighteen months simply to restore essential services and critical infrastructure, with physical infrastructure damage estimated at USD 35.2 billion. Ukrainian officials have noted that the public sector cannot meet these costs alone, and that private-sector financing could realistically cover up to 40 percent of total recovery needs if paired with structural reform — a model with implications for how ECOSOC frames blended public-private financing recommendations for other conflict-affected states.

The growing concentration of critical resources and strategic technologies further illustrates the need for coordinated international action. Global production of semiconductors, rare earth elements, lithium, cobalt, and other strategic materials remains concentrated within a limited number of countries, increasing the risk of supply disruptions and market volatility. Similarly, competition over digital infrastructure, clean energy technologies, and advanced manufacturing has highlighted the importance of balancing national security concerns with the need to preserve an open, stable, and predictable global trading system. Governments alone cannot address these challenges; meaningful progress requires cooperation with international financial institutions, the private sector, and multilateral organizations to develop sustainable investment frameworks, encourage responsible resource utilization, and ensure that national economic policies support long-term global economic resilience rather than creating disproportionate costs for other economies.

Food Security and Agricultural Recovery

Conflict is now the dominant driver of global hunger. The 2026 Global Report on Food Crises found that 266 million people across 47 countries experienced high levels of acute food insecurity in 2025 — nearly a quarter of the population analyzed and almost double the 2016 share — with roughly 70 percent of all acutely food-insecure people living in fragile or conflict-affected countries. For the first time in the report's ten-year history, two separate famines were confirmed in a single year, in parts of Gaza and Sudan, with famine risk persisting into 2026 in Gaza, Sudan, and South Sudan. More than 39 million people across 32 countries faced emergency levels of food insecurity, and the number of people experiencing catastrophic hunger has risen ninefold since 2016.

Beyond conflict and climate-related pressures, food security is increasingly influenced by national trade and resource policies that extend far beyond domestic borders. Export restrictions on staple crops, fertilizers, and agricultural inputs, alongside disruptions to global supply chains and unequal access to strategic resources, can significantly amplify food insecurity in import-dependent economies. While such measures are often introduced to safeguard domestic interests, they may unintentionally increase price volatility, constrain market access, and undermine agricultural productivity in other regions. Strengthening international cooperation on transparent trade practices, sustainable resource management, and resilient agricultural supply chains is therefore essential to ensuring that national policy decisions do not disproportionately compromise global food security or hinder progress toward the Sustainable Development Goals. The World Food Programme has separately modeled how conflict-driven energy price shocks compound this crisis: sustained oil prices above USD 100 per barrel tied to the escalation in the Middle East could push up to 45 million additional people into acute food insecurity, on top of a pre-existing baseline of 318 million, bringing the global total as high as 363 million. Import-dependent economies in sub-Saharan Africa and Asia are the most exposed, with projected increases in extreme hunger of roughly 21 percent in West and Central Africa and 24 percent in Asia. For post-conflict states specifically, rebuilding agricultural capacity — including land demining, irrigation infrastructure, seed and livestock replacement, and restoring rural supply chains — is inseparable from broader macroeconomic recovery, since food import dependence deepens exposure to exactly the price shocks that conflict itself generates.

Healthcare Systems and Essential Services

The widespread destruction of health infrastructure severely undermines every other dimension of post-conflict recovery. In Gaza, more than half of hospitals remain non-functional and over 90 percent of the territory's broader infrastructure has been affected, health-system reconstruction is now a precondition for economic activities rather than a future positive.

UNICEF's 2025 Annual Report indicates that severe funding cuts and supply shortages threaten critical medical care, including immunization, for more than 20 million children worldwide, with conflict zones bearing the heaviest impact. Rebuilding healthcare systems and infrastructure in post-conflict states requires a comprehensive approach that goes beyond physical reconstruction, re-establishing supply chains for medicines, retraining health workers who fled during conflict, and restoring routine services such as maternal care and immunization that are often the first casualties of prolonged instability.

Displacement, Return, and Human Capital Loss

Mass displacement represents not just a humanitarian crisis but also a severe depletion of the labor force and human capital required to rebuild post-conflict economies. At the end of 2025, 117.8 million people worldwide were forcibly displaced by persecution, conflict, violence, or human rights violations, including 41.6 million refugees and 68.7 million internally displaced persons (IDPs) — the majority of whom, are hosted in low- and middle-income countries. More than one-third of all forcibly displaced people originate from just four countries: Sudan, Syria, Afghanistan, and Ukraine. Sudan alone accounts for the largest single displacement crisis in the world, with 13.4 million refugees, asylum-seekers, and IDPs.

Reintegration illustrates both the opportunity and the fragility of post-conflict recovery. Following the fall of the Assad government, approximately 1.3 million refugees and nearly 1 million IDPs returned home during 2025. Yet Syria still required humanitarian assistance for over 15.6 million people, more than 60% of its population. Neighboring nations such as Jordan, Turkey and Uganda mount significant monetary and social strain from long term displacement. ECOSOC must operate as though reintegration is an essential pillar of long-term recovery rather than addressing it through isolated humanitarian channels.

Education Continuity and Long-Term Human Development

Disruption to education directly affects the long-term economic cost of conflict by weakening the future workforce a post-conflict state will need to rebuild. UNICEF estimates that more than 52 million children in conflict-affected countries are out of school, while a further 234 million school-aged children living in crisis settings require urgent support simply to access quality education.

In Gaza, 95.5 percent of all 815 schools were damaged or destroyed and all 637,000 school-aged children lacked access to formal education as of the end of 2025. In Ukraine, more than 1,600 educational facilities have been damaged or destroyed since 2022, leaving 4.6 million children facing educational barriers in the 2025-2026 school year. Across West and Central Africa, more than 14,000 schools remain closed due to conflict, affecting 2.8 million children.

If left neglected, this disruption risks creating what UN officials have termed a 'lost generation', a workforce and civic base without the foundational education that post-conflict economies require to escape cycles of poverty and renewed instability.

Infrastructure Destruction and the Cost of Rebuilding

Physical infrastructure destruction — of housing, energy grids, water systems, and transport networks — is consistently among the largest components of reconstruction cost estimates and the most direct obstacle to restarting economic activity. In Ukraine, the housing sector alone has sustained an estimated USD 61 billion in losses, the transport sector (especially rail) USD 40.3 billion, and the energy sector approximately USD 25 billion from missile strikes, with total direct damage exceeding USD 195 billion as of the RDNA5 assessment. In Gaza, the destruction of an estimated 371,888 housing units, alongside critical energy and water infrastructure, has been described by independent analysts as roughly seven times costlier to rebuild than the combined damage from the three preceding rounds of conflict in the territory. These figures illustrate why ECOSOC's coordinating role — linking Member

States, international financial institutions, and UN specialized agencies around sequenced, sector-by-sector reconstruction financing — is central to preventing infrastructure gaps from becoming permanent development traps.

As economies become increasingly interconnected, disruptions caused by unilateral trade measures, export restrictions, and unequal access to strategic resources can significantly hinder economic activity beyond national borders. Dependence on a limited number of suppliers for semiconductors, critical minerals, and energy has exposed vulnerabilities that can increase production costs, disrupt supply chains, and slow economic growth, particularly in developing economies. These challenges highlight ECOSOC's coordinating role in making sure everything is laid down perfectly - things ranging from international cooperation all the way to policy frameworks to minimize impacts that can cause such catastrophes.

Conclusion

Post-conflict recovery is not a single-sector challenge but a compounding one: financing gaps deepen food insecurity, collapsed health systems undermine human capital, displacement drains the labor force a recovering economy needs, interrupted education mortgages a state's future productivity, and destroyed infrastructure raises the cost of every other recovery effort. ECOSOC's mandate to coordinate across the UN's economic, social, humanitarian, and financial institutions positions it uniquely — though not operationally — to convene the sequencing and financing conversations that determine whether a post-conflict state achieves durable recovery or slides back into fragility. The Council's task is to identify concrete, coordinated mechanisms — blending public concessional finance, private capital, and UN system technical assistance — that allow reconstruction to begin before humanitarian relief ends, rather than after it.

Questions to Consider

1. How can ECOSOC help close the financing gap between short-term humanitarian relief and long-term development finance for fragile and conflict-affected states?
2. What role should blended public-private financing instruments, such as catalytic risk-sharing funds, play in de-risking investment in post-conflict economies?
3. How should reconstruction efforts sequence and prioritize competing needs — food security, healthcare, education, housing, and infrastructure — when financing is constrained?
4. What mechanisms can support the sustainable reintegration of returning refugees and IDPs without overburdening host communities and states?
5. How can the international community prevent interrupted education during conflict from producing a long-term 'lost generation' effect on post-conflict economies?
6. What can ECOSOC learn from recent damage and needs assessments (e.g., Ukraine, Gaza) in designing a more general framework for post-conflict economic recovery?

Helpful Links

1. <https://www.wfp.org/publications/global-report-food-crises-grfc>
2. <https://www.unhcr.org/about-unhcr/overview/figures-glance>
3. <https://www.unicef.org/reports/unicef-annual-report/2025>
4. <https://www.worldbank.org/en/news/press-release/2026/02/23/updated-ukraine-recovery-and-reconstruction-needs-assessment-released>
5. <https://www.un.org/unispal/document/final-gaza-press-release-20apr26/>
6. <https://www.imf.org/en/topics/fragile-and-conflict-affected-states>
7. <https://www.undp.org/news/uncdf-undp-and-qatar-fund-development-call-global-partners-unlock-finance-conflict-affected-and-fragile-settings>